

SKILLS FOR THE JOB

for strategic decision-making. “A deep understanding of the P&L (profit and loss) statement, business drivers, capital allocation, and risk management is invaluable. Ultimately, an organisation works towards its P&L statement and balance sheet, and knowing exactly how these end deliverables are built is a significant advantage,” she says. The shift, however, required a different mindset. “I had to unlearn the instinct of default financial optimisation and instead prioritise long-term value creation,” she says.

The cultural shift was equally significant. As CFO, she was often a peer or trusted advisor. “As CEO, the dynamic changed—I became the final decision-maker. This required more intentional communication and a leadership style that empowered others rather than simply partnering with them.” She says understanding customer lifetime value or market innovation cycles is now as critical as monitoring earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation. “Finance leaders should help quantify the value of investments in research and development, customer experience, and sustainability. This requires a shift from post-mortem analysis to forward-looking, scenario-based thinking.”

Bhaduri says these shifts demand a wider skillset—one that modern CFOs are increasingly developing. They need the architect’s eye (strategic thinking) to see how every financial decision shapes the overall business strategy; the storyteller’s voice (communication and influence) to translate complex financial data into compelling narratives; the tech whisperer’s fluency (digital acumen) to leverage artificial intelligence, data analytics, and digital tools for smarter decisions; and the people mover’s approach to lead with empathy, inspire teams, and foster accountability and innovation.

WHAT BOARDS LOOK FOR

When boards and search committees evaluate CFOs for the CEO role today, the conversation goes far beyond financial expertise. There is a clear emphasis on leadership.



FINANCIAL DISCIPLINE



BOARDROOM EXPERIENCE



STRATEGIC INSIGHT



MANAGING LARGE BANKING RELATIONSHIPS



FORWARD- LOOKING THINKING

“Boards are looking for some evidence of leadership beyond finance—this could mean oversight of ESG, driving operational efficiencies, or even leading and incubating a smaller business alongside the finance function,” says Katara.

Internally, pathways from CFO to CEO are gaining traction. CFOs who demonstrate strong business leadership competencies are often given expanded portfolios—combining CFO with COO responsibilities. There’s also a growing expectation for CFOs to harness technology. The rapid pace of AI adoption has altered what companies require from finance leaders. The ability to leverage AI for efficiencies and cost savings is no longer optional—it’s a critical competency.

UNCONVENTIONAL PATHS

Aspiring finance leaders can sharpen their readiness for the top job by stepping beyond the boundaries of their function and gaining a wider perspective of the business. Bhaduri says this begins with immersion—spending time in operational areas like sales, the factory floor, or customer service.

Some CFOs choose to become a “shadow CEO,” observing leaders up close to absorb their approach to communication, crisis management, and inspiration. It’s also about learning how to translate complex financial concepts into compelling narratives. Kashiramka stresses the importance of adopting a growth mindset: “The CFO path teaches precision and certainty, but leadership at the next level requires adaptability, humility, and the ability to navigate ambiguity. The sooner you embrace that shift, the more prepared you’ll be.”

Jain believes the biggest hurdle for CFOs aspiring to become CEO is overcoming perceptions. “The key challenge is the mindset of people first looking at you as the CFO, which means the ‘finance guy’ only,” he says.

Breaking that mould, Jain explains, begins with self-transformation: “This requires a change in yourself, or rather in the way you present yourself. Once you succeed in that, the journey ahead becomes much easier.” **BT**